

Roland J-6 - Style, Variation & Sequencer Reference

Reference for the STYLE/VARIATION phrase engine, plus the step-sequencer mechanics that determine which phrase a step plays and how notes actually get recorded onto the grid.

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STYLE and VARIATION turn a held chord into a phrase: an arpeggio, a rhythmic gate pattern, or a chord-level rhythm/strum. Styles 1-3 are melodic (single-note arpeggios), Styles 4-5 are rhythmic gating of the whole chord, and Styles 6-9 move the whole chord as a block (rhythmic comping, not single-note motion).

ARPEGGIO STYLES - melodic motion (1, 2, 3)

Style 1 - Classic 8th-Note Arpeggios

Traditional 8th-note arpeggiated motion, up / down / alternating. Traces the chord's notes in time rather than holding them as a block.

Var.	Pattern	Use it for
1	UP1 (8th, ascending)	Bright rising bassline or lead; good opening phrase
2	UP&DOWN1 (8th, up/down)	Balanced melodic motion for evolving chords
3	DOWN1 (8th, descending)	Falling bassline; moody transitions
4	DOWN2 (8th, alt. descent)	Descending variation, added rhythmic interest
5	UP&DOWN2 (8th, alt.)	Double-direction motion under sustained chords
6	UP2 (8th, alt. ascend)	Faster upward arps for energetic sections
7-12	Triplet versions of 1-6	Swing / shuffle feel; funk or jazz-leaning parts

Style 2 - 16th-Note Arpeggio Motion

Same UP/DOWN/UP&DOWN family as Style 1, on 16th-note subdivisions - tighter, faster motion.

Var.	Pattern	Use it for
1	UP1 (16th, ascending)	Fast rhythmic lead or bass figure
2	UP&DOWN1 (16th)	Busy, pulsing arpeggio motion
3	DOWN1 (16th, descending)	Quick descending fills
4	DOWN2 (16th, alt. descent)	Slightly varied downward feel
5	UP&DOWN2 (16th, alt.)	Complex bidirectional lines
6	UP2 (16th, alt. ascend)	High-energy melodic runs
7-12	16th triplet versions	Groove-oriented arps with swing

Style 3 - Stepped Note Arpeggios

Long note values (double whole down to sixteenth, plus their triplets). Spacious, atmospheric arpeggiation rather than rhythmic drive.

Var.	Note value	Use it for
1	Double whole note	Very slow motion under ambient pads
2	Whole note	Slow arpeggio fills
3	Half note	Broader melodic pacing
4	Quarter note	Subtle motion under chords
5	Eighth note	Moderate arpeggio pacing
6	Sixteenth note	Faster but still spaced motion
7-12	Triplet versions of 1-6	Varied rhythmic feel with swing

Arpeggio styles (1-3) are the go-to for melodic or bassline motion, fast or slow.

BEAT STYLES - rhythmic gating of the chord (4, 5)

Style 4 - Basic Rhythmic Patterns

Turns the held chord into a rhythmic pulse pattern: the whole chord gates on and off on specific 16th/8th positions. Timing over melodic motion.

Var.	Pattern	Use it for
1	o___ (16th hit, rest)	Simple rhythmic stab under pads
2	_o__ (syncopated 16th)	Off-beat accents in grooves
3	__o_ (late 16th)	Delay-like rhythmic feel
4	___o (very late 16th)	Sparse late hits
5	o~o_ (8th + 16th)	Groove with uneven feel
6	o_o~ (8th/16th syncopation)	More complex rhythm
7-12	16th groupings	Varied rhythmic punctuations

Style 5 - Syncopated Rhythmic Motion

Heavier syncopation and rhythmic variety on top of the Style 4 gating idea - grooves with more push and accent placement.

Var.	Pattern	Use it for
1	o___ (sync 16th)	Strong starter hits under chords
2	o_o_ (syncopated 16ths)	Funky, off-beat chord drive
3	o__o (paired 16ths)	Repeating rhythmic pushes
4	_oo_ (grouped sync)	Clustered rhythmic accents
5	_o_o (offset sync)	Jumpier rhythm
6	__oo (tight 16th pair)	Fast rhythmic duet
7-12	Extended sync groupings	More sync accent feel

A note on style category names

The manual's own category header groups Style 3 under "BEAT" and Styles 4-9 under "PHRASE" - this sheet uses "Beat Styles" more loosely for 4-5 because their rhythmic-gating character groups naturally with Style 3 from a user's-ear perspective. If you ever cross-reference the manual directly, the category boundary it draws sits after Style 3, not after Style 5.

Beat styles (4-5) are for rhythmic support under sustained harmony, not melodic motion.

CHORD / PHRASE STYLES - the chord moves as a block (6, 7, 8, 9)

These four styles treat the whole chord as a unit rather than breaking it into single-note arpeggios. This is the family to use for a step that should sound like a chord hit rather than a moving line. Unlike Styles 1-5, the manual gives only a style-level category label here - no per-variation breakdown is published for variations 1-12 within any of these four styles. "Simple" vs "Rhythmic" is the one documented distinction; anything more granular needs auditioning on the unit, not reading off this sheet.

Style 6 - Chord Phrases (Simple)

Structured chord-phrase patterns, harmonic motion without the rhythmic subdivision of Style 7. The closest documented candidate for a step that should read as a held chord rather than an arpeggio - but "Simple" is a relative label, not a guarantee of zero motion. Audition Variation 1 before committing it to a sequence.

Var.	Category	Use it for
1-12	Chord Phrases (Simple) - no published breakdown	Basic chord backing, predictable motion

Style 7 - Chord Phrases (Rhythmic)

More rhythmic movement on the chord phrase than Style 6 - pulsing, groove-oriented, still voiced as a block chord rather than single notes.

Var.	Category	Use it for
1-12	Chord Phrases (Rhythmic) - no published breakdown	Groove chords that move with beat emphasis

Style 8 - Strummed Chord Phrases (Simple)

Simulates strum-like chord movement, closer to guitar or piano comping than to a synth arpeggio.

Var.	Category	Use it for
1-12	Strummed Chord Phrases (Simple) - no published breakdown	Acoustic-like backing or rhythmic pulse

Style 9 - Strummed Chord Phrases (Rhythmic)

Rhythmic counterpart to Style 8 - more pronounced groove and swing on top of the strummed character.

Var.	Category	Use it for
1-12	Strummed Chord Phrases (Rhythmic) - no published breakdown	More pronounced groove and swing

Chord/phrase styles (6-9) are for when the full chord should have motion - comping or rhythmic chord backing - rather than single-note movement.

SEQUENCING BEHAVIOR - what STYLE ON/OFF per step actually does

This is the part the article above does not cover, and the part that caused the confusion in the conversation that produced this sheet. It is reconstructed from the official J-6 Owner's Manual (v1.02), "Using the Sequencer" and "Using the Phrase Function" sections.

1. OFF is not "no phrase" - it is "inherit the previous phrase"

- A step with STYLE OFF does not play a plain chord. It continues playing whichever Style/Variation was last assigned by an ON step before it in playback order.
- If no ON step has occurred yet when playback reaches an OFF step, that step falls back to the pattern's own default phrase setting.
- There is no per-step state for "phrase engine disabled" - every step is always rendered through some Style/Variation, assigned or inherited.

2. "Plain chord" is itself a phrase choice, not the absence of one

- To get a step that sounds like a held chord rather than an arpeggio, assign it **STYLE ON, Style 6, Variation 1** (Chord Phrases, Simple) - not STYLE OFF. Treat this as the best documented candidate, not a guaranteed flat chord: the manual gives no per-variation detail for Style 6, so confirm by ear.
- Leaving such a step at STYLE OFF after an arpeggiated step will simply continue the arpeggio: the OFF state has no opinion of its own.

3. Per-step assignment is "from here on," not "this step only"

- An ON assignment persists forward until the next ON step overrides it - across page boundaries, for the rest of the pattern if nothing follows.
- Practically: every block of consecutive steps that should sound the same way needs exactly one ON step at its start, carrying the Style/Variation for that whole block. The steps after it can stay OFF and will correctly inherit it.

Recipe: alternating "variation" steps and "chord" steps

Step role	STYLE button	Style / Variation	Resulting sound
First step of an arpeggio block	ON	e.g. Style 1, Variation 1	Arpeggio starts here
Following steps in that block	OFF	(inherited)	Arpeggio continues
First step of a "chord" block	ON	Style 6, Variation 1	Switches to chord-phrase (audition first)
Following steps in that block	OFF	(inherited)	Plain chord continues

Boundary rule: every transition between a "variation" block and a "chord" block requires a fresh ON step at the start of the new block. There is no shortcut where OFF reverts to a default; OFF only ever means "same as before."

Sources: Roland_J6_Style_Variations.html (musicrigs.com, accessed 2026) for the Style 1-5 pattern tables (verified against the manual); Roland J-6 Owner's Manual v1.02, "Using the Sequencer", "Using the Phrase Function", and the "Phrase List" table (p.34, extracted via pdftotext -layout from the official PDF to preserve column alignment), for the sequencing-behavior section and the Style 6-9 category mapping. Style 6, Variation 1 is the best-documented candidate for a chord-like step; not independently confirmed by ear on the unit.

THE BEAT PARAMETER - step length and real-time recording

Not to be confused with the "Beat Styles" label used earlier in this sheet for Styles 4-5, nor with the manual's own "BEAT" category, which covers only Style 3. This BEAT is a separate, pattern-level menu parameter (SHIFT + MENU → bEAt) that sets the sequencer's step grid - the same word used three different ways on this one instrument.

What it actually sets

- BEAT sets the rhythmic value of one sequencer step: 1-4 = sixteenth note, 1-3 = eighth-note triplet, 1-2 = eighth note, and the full range 1-8 sets the number of steps per quarter note in general.
- A pattern is capped at 64 steps (8 pages of 8). Total pattern duration is therefore **step count x BEAT note-value** - changing BEAT changes both the grid's fineness and how much musical time the pattern spans, at the same time. There is no way to get finer resolution without losing duration, or more duration without losing resolution.
- There is no separate "quantize strength" control layered on top of continuous timing. BEAT is the only clock the recorder has - a note is written into whichever step is current at the moment you play it. There is no documented swing or sub-step precision.

Choosing a value for a given part

Set BEAT to match the shortest note value actually present in the part, not an average. Anything faster than the grid has nowhere to land except on top of its neighbor, since one step holds one note/chord slot.

Reference: steps required per 4/4 measure

BEAT value	Note value	Steps / quarter note	Steps / measure	Max measures @ 64 steps
1	Quarter note	1	4	16
1-2	Eighth note	2	8	8
1-3	Eighth-note triplet	3	12	5.33
1-4	Sixteenth note	4	16	4
5	(undocumented label)	5	20	3.2
6	(undocumented label)	6	24	2.67
7	(undocumented label)	7	28	2.29
8	Thirty-second note	8	32	2

Computed from the manual's stated relationship (steps per quarter note); not a table printed in the manual itself. Non-integer rows (1-3, 5, 6, 7) mean a full 4/4 measure does not land on an exact step boundary at the 64-step ceiling - usable, but the pattern's last measure will be cut short of a clean bar line unless you accept a non-power-of-two pattern length.

Ties and real-time recording - confirmed on hardware

Ties (HOLD button, extending a note into the following step) are documented only as a manual step-edit action. Confirmed directly on the unit: real-time recording does not auto-generate ties from how long a key is physically held - it only captures note-on events, quantized to the step grid. **Any note meant to sustain across more than one step must be tied in afterward, by hand, in step-edit mode** - there is no real-time workflow for recording note duration, which is a genuine limitation for playing pads expressively rather than programming step-by-step.

BEAT PARAMETER - lineage and nomenclature

Why BEAT, not "resolution"

Classic TR-808/909 drum machines had a fixed 16-step sixteenth-note grid with no selectable subdivision whatsoever - to play faster, you doubled the tempo. The TR-8/TR-8S generation introduced a parameter called SCALE serving the identical purpose. The J-6 inherits the mechanism, renaming it BEAT to avoid a collision with the word "scale," which already carries strong harmonic meaning on a chord synthesizer. The segment-display form (bEAt) is a display-width constraint applied uniformly across all menu entries, not a choice specific to this parameter.

"Resolution" would import a false assumption from software sequencers, where grid fineness and loop length are decoupled. On the J-6 they are not: the step count is capped, so changing BEAT changes both simultaneously. The parameter name BEAT, defined as "the note value of one step," states the actual mechanism rather than borrowing a metaphor that does not transfer.

Sources: Roland J-6 Owner's Manual v1.02, "Changing the step length (BEAT)", the menu list entry for "bEAt" (p.19), "Inputting notes in real time" (p.14), and "Inputting consecutive ties" (p.12). Lineage context (BEAT as a descendant of the TR-8/TR-8S "SCALE" parameter) is general product history, not drawn from the J-6 manual.